

Mapping With Melanin™ — Sundown Towns Implementation Gates

GATE 2: Tougaloo College Outreach Email (DRAFT — send from your email)

To: Contact form or email at justice.tougaloo.edu

Subject: Attribution Request — Historical Sundown Towns Database in Community Safety App

Dear Dr. Berrey and the Tougaloo History & Social Justice team,

My name is [YOUR NAME], and I am the founder of Mapping With Melanin™, a community-powered mobile application designed to help minority communities navigate safely, find trusted businesses, and connect culturally across the United States.

I am writing to respectfully request guidance on proper attribution for referencing the Historical Sundown Towns Database in our platform. Our app includes a community safety layer that helps users understand the historical context of areas they may be traveling through or relocating to. We believe the foundational research conducted by Dr. James Loewen and continued by your team is essential to providing our community with accurate, respectful historical context.

How we intend to use the data:

- We reference the "Historical Sundown Towns Linked to US Census Geographies" dataset (Rigby et al., 2025, Scientific Data) which builds upon your database
- Historical sundown town indicators appear as a persistent safety awareness layer on our map
- Each indicator includes a clear attribution statement crediting the Tougaloo database and Dr. Loewen's research
- We distinguish between historical documentation and current community-reported experiences
- We never use the data to stigmatize communities — our framing is "historical context for awareness," not "dangerous area"
- Community members can provide current-day updates (positive or negative) that supplement the historical record

What we are requesting:

1. Confirmation that our intended use aligns with your database's terms of use
2. Your preferred attribution language (we want to get this exactly right)
3. Any guidance on how you'd like the historical context framed when presented to users
4. Whether you'd like to be listed as a data partner or prefer a simpler citation

Our proposed attribution (pending your approval):

"Historical sundown town data is based on research by Dr. James W. Loewen and the Tougaloo College History & Social Justice Project (justice.tougaloo.edu), with spatial linkage from Rigby et al. (2025). This indicator reflects documented historical practices and does not represent current conditions. Community members are encouraged to share their present-day experiences."

We deeply respect the work your team has done to preserve this history and make it accessible. Our goal is to honor that work while helping our community stay informed and safe.

I would be happy to schedule a call or provide additional details about our platform. Thank you for your time and for the invaluable work you continue to do.

Warm regards,

[YOUR NAME]

Founder, Mapping With Melanin™

[YOUR EMAIL]

[YOUR PHONE — optional]

mappingwithmelanin.com

GATE 5: Replit Instructions — Sundown Towns Visual Design

Pin Shape & Color System

Color: Muted amber/ochre — #B8860B (dark goldenrod)

This color was chosen because:

- Warm enough to be visible on the map
- NOT red (red implies present-day danger — these are historical indicators)
- NOT black (too ominous)
- Evokes aged parchment / historical marker plaques

- Distinct from business pins (gold circles) and heritage pins (colored diamonds)

Shape: Triangles — visually distinct from all other pin types

Confidence Level	Shape	Visual	Description
Confirmed	Solid triangle	▲	Strong historical evidence — documented ordinances, newspaper records, multiple sources
Probable	Semi-filled triangle	⬆	Significant evidence — census patterns, oral histories, some documentation
Possible	Outline/dashed triangle	△	Some evidence — limited documentation, single source, or inference from demographic data

Size & Z-Index

- Size: Slightly smaller than business pins (these are context, not destinations)
- Z-index: Below active safety alerts, above base map, same level as heritage pins
- Opacity: 80% (slightly transparent — historical, not in-your-face)
- At high zoom: individual triangles visible
- At low zoom: cluster into a count badge with the triangle icon

Tap Card (what users see when they tap a sundown town triangle)

Plain Text

▲ Historical Context

[Place Name], [State]

Confidence: Confirmed / Probable / Possible

"This area has a documented history of restricting the movement or residency of people of color. This indicator reflects historical practices and does not represent current conditions."

 Historical Evidence

[Summary from dataset comments field]

 Community Updates (3)

"I visited in 2025 and felt welcome" ✓

"Still feels unwelcoming after dark" ⚠

[Share Your Experience]

[Learn More]

Data: Tougaloo College / Loewen (2005)

Spatial: Rigby et al. (2025)

Language Rules (LOCKED — never change these)

Always say	Never say
"Historical context"	"Dangerous area"
"Documented history of restricting movement"	"Racist town"
"People of color"	"Black people" (unless historically specific)
"This indicator reflects historical practices"	"This area is unsafe"
"Does not represent current conditions"	"Still dangerous today"
"Community members have reported feeling unwelcoming"	"Crime is high here"
"Exercise awareness"	"Avoid this area"

State Evolution (from the Map UX Spec)

Sundown town indicators can EVOLVE based on community reports:

State	Trigger	Visual Change
Historical Neutral	Default (no recent community data)	Standard amber triangle
Historical Softened	3+ positive community reports in 12 months	Triangle with green dot overlay
Historical Confirmed	3+ negative community reports confirming unwelcoming	Triangle with orange dot overlay
Current Active	5+ negative reports in 60 days (present-day hostility)	Triangle turns solid orange, slightly larger
Current Escalated	10+ reports OR safety alert	Triangle turns dark orange, pulsing border
Current Faded	6+ months of only positive reports	Triangle becomes very faint (20% opacity)

Data Source

- Primary: OSF dataset (osf.io/fh7r6/) — 2,248 historical sundown places with geocodes
- Confidence levels in the dataset map directly to our Confirmed/Probable/Possible system
- Each record has Census geocodes (linkable to 1940-2020 boundaries)
- Comments field provides historical evidence summary for the tap card

Implementation Notes

1. Import the 2,248 records from the OSF dataset into a `sundown_towns` table
2. Each record gets: name, state, latitude, longitude, confidence_level, historical_evidence (from comments), census_geocode, current_state (default: "historical_neutral")
3. The layer is ALWAYS ON — users cannot hide it (per Map UX Spec non-negotiable rule #2)
4. Community reports on sundown town indicators go into a separate `sundown_community_reports` table
5. State transitions are calculated on read (count reports in timeframe, determine current state)

6. Attribution footer appears on every tap card

Build Assignment

This goes into **Build 107** (Safety & Trust system) per the Build Roadmap. Do NOT implement before the tour — this requires the Tougaloo attribution confirmation (Gate 2) and the OSF license verification (Gate 1) to be complete first.

GATE 1: License Status (for your records)

- Article: Rigby et al. (2025), Scientific Data, Nature. DOI: 10.1038/s41597-024-04330-9
- Article license: CC BY 4.0 (standard for all Scientific Data publications)
- Data license: Available on OSF (osf.io/fh7r6/) "through a universal license" — likely CC0 or CC BY 4.0
- Action needed: Visit osf.io/fh7r6/ and check the license badge on the data files to confirm exact terms
- Either way (CC0 or CC BY 4.0): You are clear to use the data with attribution
- The attribution in the tap card footer satisfies CC BY 4.0 requirements